

STAGE THREE • JOB APPLICATION & INTERVIEW SKILLS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 20 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Three • Job Application & Interview Skills

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Three, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Three's manual presents its twenty FIRSTS as a flat list with no named sections. This guide, along with the companion Session Plan, Group Versions of Key Exercises, Icebreakers, and Discussion Prompts documents, organizes them into three sessions: Building the Application (C1–C7), Interview Readiness (C8–C14), and Closing the Loop (C15–C20).

Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt. Suggested times are for framing and discussion only; independent and paired practice time is scheduled separately in the companion Session Plan.

SESSION 1

Building the Application

Covers *FIRSTS C1-C7*

FIRST C1

Job Application Tracker

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up a working tracker with all eight core columns and log every application already sent this season.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- At real volume (15, 30, or more applications), memory alone fails — missed follow-ups and duplicate applications quietly cost real opportunities.
- The tracker only has value if it's actually reviewed, not just updated once and forgotten.
- This is the operational foundation for the entire stage; nearly everything else assumes this system exists.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Updating the tracker sporadically rather than as a consistent habit.
 - Tracking applications but never actually reviewing it to catch overdue follow-ups.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min (hands-on setup)*

FIRST C2

Application Strategy

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants list their must-have and nice-to-have criteria and name five companies genuinely meeting the must-haves.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many loosely matched applications with an identical resume typically underperform fewer, well-matched, tailored ones.
- Strategy is what turns job searching from a stressful numbers game into something more controllable.
- Both extremes are real risks: too narrow starves the pipeline, too broad dilutes effort across weak matches.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Spreading effort so thin across too many applications that none gets a genuine chance.
 - Narrowing so much that too few real opportunities remain in the pipeline.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST C3

Resume Version A/B Test

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a second resume version differing from their current one in exactly one clear, testable way.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Generic resume advice doesn't apply equally to every field or candidate — real testing produces data specific to your actual situation.
- One variable at a time is non-negotiable; changing several things at once makes the result impossible to interpret.
- This is genuinely a multi-week exercise — frame today as launching the test, not completing it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Testing two versions too similar to produce any meaningful difference.
- Changing multiple variables at once, making it impossible to tell what actually mattered.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C4

Cover Letter Customization

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify three swappable elements in their base letter and fully customize one for a real target company in 20 minutes.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A fully generic letter is easy to spot and rarely persuasive, but full rewrites don't scale at real application volume.
- Efficient customization is the sustainable middle path — swap specific elements deeply, not just the company name.
- This is directly testable today with a real target company, not hypothetical.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Swapping in only the company name while leaving generic language everywhere else.
- Over-customizing to the point where it can't be sustained across real application volume.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C5

Job Listing Analysis

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants complete a full two-pass keyword analysis on one real job posting from their target list.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Repeated language and requirement order are genuine signals of what a hiring manager actually cares about most.
- Most candidates skim past these signals entirely, missing free information about how to tailor their materials.
- Not every listed skill is equally required — the posting's own language usually distinguishes must-haves from nice-to-haves.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skimming only the job title and first sentence.
- Treating every listed skill as equally required regardless of the posting's actual emphasis.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C6

STAR Answer Prep

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write their single strongest professional or academic story in full STAR format.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without structure, candidates under real pressure ramble, bury the point, or forget the outcome entirely.
- STAR specifically protects the Result from getting lost — the part interviewers actually remember most.
- Practiced, not memorized word-for-word — a rigid script sounds robotic rather than conversational.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Spending most of the answer on Situation and Task while rushing or forgetting the Result.
- Memorizing the story so rigidly it sounds robotic rather than conversational.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C7

Behavioral Interview Prep

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice answering three unprepared behavioral questions out loud using stories from their STAR bank.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Behavioral questions appear in nearly every interview process, regardless of industry.
- Unpracticed candidates often freeze or default to generic answers even when they have genuinely strong real experiences.
- One story forced awkwardly into every answer is a common, avoidable pattern — push for a bank of several distinct stories.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Preparing stories but never practicing them out loud under any real time pressure.

- Having only one story that gets awkwardly forced into every answer.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 2

Interview Readiness

Covers *FIRSTS C8-C14*

FIRST C8

Technical Interview Prep

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify their target role's specific technical format and complete one practice problem in that exact format today.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Technical interviews test applied skill under real time pressure and observation — genuinely different from solving the same problem alone, untimed.
- Even genuinely skilled candidates can underperform without simulated practice matching real conditions.
- Understanding the underlying concept matters more than memorizing a specific answer.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Practicing only in comfortable, untimed, solo conditions that don't resemble the real interview experience.
 - Reviewing answers without genuinely understanding the underlying concept.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C9

Case/Problem-Solving Prep

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants solve one practice case, spending two minutes structuring their approach first and narrating their thinking out loud.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Case interviews test how you think under genuine ambiguity, not just whether you reach a correct final answer.
- A framework is a starting structure, not a rigid script to apply mechanically regardless of the specific case.
- Narrating your thinking out loud, even alone in practice, builds the habit real case interviews require.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Memorizing framework templates so rigidly they're applied mechanically instead of adapted to the specific case.
- Practicing only silently instead of narrating your thought process aloud.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C10

Mock Interview

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reach out to one potential mock interview partner today and schedule a real session before their next actual interview.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Reading about interview technique and actually performing under real conversational pressure are genuinely different experiences.
- A mock interview is the closest available simulation before the real thing.
- The honest feedback conversation afterward is where much of the real learning happens — don't let it get skipped.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Choosing a partner who already knows all your answers, which removes realistic unpredictability.
- Skipping the honest feedback conversation afterward.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min to schedule (session itself happens outside this time block)

FIRST C11

Job Offer Negotiation Prep

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants research a realistic salary range for one target role and write down both a target number and a walk-away number.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most first offers have genuine room built in for negotiation.
- Fear of seeming ungrateful can cost meaningful compensation over an entire career, not just one offer.
- Research beforehand prevents negotiating blind, which undermines confidence in the actual conversation.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Not researching a realistic range beforehand and negotiating blind.
- Being too aggressive without acknowledging genuine enthusiasm for the role.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST C12

Follow-Up Email After Interview

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a follow-up email template with a placeholder for a specific conversation detail to fill in after each real interview.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A well-written follow-up can reinforce a strong impression and occasionally tip a genuinely close decision.
- A missing or generic one is a small, easily avoidable missed opportunity.
- The template needs a genuine personalization placeholder — a template with nothing to fill in defeats its own purpose.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sending a generic template with no reference to the actual conversation.
- Waiting several days to send it, well past when it's genuinely useful.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST C13

Test/Assessment Prep

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants research which assessment type their top target company uses and find one practice question in that exact format.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many companies use standardized assessments as an early screening step.
- Candidates unfamiliar with the specific format, timing, or question style can underperform relative to their genuine ability.
- Different companies genuinely use different formats — never assume they're all the same.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Practicing only untimed, unlike the real assessment conditions.
- Assuming all assessments from different companies use the same format.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST C14

Mock Presentation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants time their current presentation draft and identify the single section they'd cut first if they needed to save two minutes.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Some interview processes include a presentation component specifically to evaluate organization and delivery under time pressure.
- This is a genuinely different skill from answering conversational questions well.
- The follow-up question portion after a formal presentation is often under-practiced relative to the talk itself.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Cramming too much content into the available time limit.
- Never practicing the follow-up question portion that typically comes after a formal presentation.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 3

Closing the Loop

Covers *FIRSTS C15–C20*

FIRST C15

Interview Mindset Routine

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants design a three-part pre-interview routine and practice it once before a real low-stakes situation this week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Even well-prepared candidates can underperform if nerves take over in the moments right before an interview.
- A consistent routine provides something reliable to lean on regardless of how nervous a given day feels.
- Testing it on a genuinely low-stakes situation this week builds real confidence before the actual high-stakes moment.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using cramming or last-minute rereading as a de facto “routine” instead of a genuinely calming, focus-building one.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST C16

Thank-You Email Habit

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants commit, out loud or in writing, to sending a thank-you email after every interview this season, no exceptions.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A single good follow-up is useful; a consistent habit across every interview builds a genuine professional reputation.
- This includes interviews that went poorly or resulted in rejection — the relationship-building value doesn't depend on the outcome.
- A public or written commitment genuinely increases real follow-through compared to a private intention alone.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only sending thank-you emails after interviews that felt successful, missing the relationship value of the ones that didn't.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 10 min

FIRST C17

Application Deadline Calendar

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up a dedicated, color-coded calendar for their job search and add every deadline currently on their radar.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A job search often overlaps with a full course load or existing job, and deadlines get lost among competing commitments.
- A calendar with active reminders works meaningfully better than a spreadsheet that's only checked occasionally.
- This should be set up live, in-session, not just planned for later.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Tracking deadlines only in a spreadsheet that isn't checked daily, rather than a calendar with active reminders.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min (hands-on setup)*

FIRST C18

Career-Focused LinkedIn Application

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants search their top target company on LinkedIn and identify one real connection, even a distant one, to reach out to this week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Cold applications, especially at larger companies, often get filtered by automated systems before a human ever sees them.
- A referral or warm introduction can route an application directly to a hiring manager instead.
- Genuine context in the outreach message matters far more than the connection itself — a cold, contextless ask to a stranger is easily ignored.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking a stranger for a referral immediately with no context, which often gets ignored.
- Only using this approach after already submitting many cold applications with no results, rather than from the start.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST C19

Job Research Sheet

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants complete a full research sheet for their next scheduled interview and draft two specific questions based on what they find.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Interviewers can easily tell the difference between genuine research and a five-minute homepage skim.
- The difference shows up directly in the quality and specificity of the questions a candidate asks.
- This should be done for a real, upcoming interview whenever one exists, not a hypothetical company.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only reading the homepage “about us” page.
 - Preparing generic questions that could apply to any company rather than ones specific to real findings.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST C20

Offer Comparison Matrix

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build an empty comparison matrix template, listing and weighting the factors that matter most to them before any real offer arrives.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Real offers, especially more than one at once, bring genuine pressure and excitement that can cloud clear thinking.
- A structured comparison keeps the eventual decision grounded in real priorities established back in Stages One and Two, not in the moment's emotion.
- Building this before an offer exists means the framework is ready and unbiased when real stakes arrive.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Building the matrix but then ignoring it in favor of the highest number anyway.
 - Forgetting to weight factors by their actual importance to you specifically, rather than a generic priority order.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*